

By Anirudh Regidi

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Somewhere in Africa

Ombassa leaned heavily on his stick, for he was tired, so very tired, and stared, albeit unseeingly, into the red glare of the flames that spread before him. His face showed no sign of any weariness however; it was an aged, lined, weather-worn face that had seen much suffering and little joy in its time. You could see the dancing fingers of flame reflected in his sightless eyes, the ruddy glow of the fire bathing his face in a shimmering, orange light.

Emotion did not come easy to this old, weather-beaten farmer. Privation and hardship were as much a part of his life as the air he was breathing or the red soil beneath his feet. He did not even flinch when the wind swung around and blew the thick, black, billowing smoke into his face, stinging his eyes. He just stood there, still as a statue, watching the ravenous tongues of flame devour his plantation, one tree at a time. He stood there for a long time.

Night fell on the field, a bright moon in the sky. Akeya was making his way to the field in search of Ombassa. It was late and the cold night wouldn't do the old man any good. The news of the blight had hit Akeya hard, but not as hard as it had hit Ombassa he assumed. Jojo was pregnant with Akeya's first child, Ombassa's first grandchild, and both men had been hoping for a bountiful banana harvest and a year with food in their bellies.

Curse that blight! It had been running rampant through their village, relentlessly moving from one plantation to the next, laying waste to produce that meant the difference between life and death to these poor farmers. They had taken all the precautions they could when setting up their plantation and for a while it seemed like that their effort had paid off, theirs



Farmers in rural areas struggle to purchase seeds, let alone fertilizer.



Who are we to deny them an education? Simple ignorance on our part is no excuse.

was the only plantation untouched and even Ombassa had begun to hope. But that hope was fleeting. The blight took their fields as it did all the others, even if theirs was the last plantation to fall, which was no consolation whatsoever.

Akeya spotted Ombassa in the distance, silhouetted by the still smouldering

remains of the field. He walked up to where Ombassa was standing and spared one long, sorrowful glance at the shattered dreams and lost hope that the burning embers represented. Almost unconsciously, he reached up and touched his father-in-law's shoulder. Ombassa stirred and seemed to notice Akeya for the first